

"This is by far the most important station in the East..... of much higher value than whole continents of territory; if no untimely fate awaits it, it promises to become the emporium and pride of the East."

- Sir Stamford Raffles
(1781-1826)
founder of the city of
Singapore

Undergraduate Studies

Destination Singapore

Why study in Singapore?

For many Indians, Singapore is the ultimate tourist spot — loads of shopping, lots of sightseeing, great food, you name it. But did you know that it is rising fast in the ranks of best places to study in? Its universities rank among the top 25 in the world, and among the top five in Asia. The Singapore government accords great importance to education, evident from the fact that it spends nearly one-fifth of the annual budget each year on education-related expenditure. The emphasis on the importance of education is further echoed by the local attitudes, which promote excellence.

Besides the high quality of education, studying in Singapore offers several other advantages:

- **Cheaper**: The cost of education and living in Singapore is at least 30 per cent less than that of the UK or US. In addition, international students who have secured admission to study in Singapore are eligible to apply for a tuition grant from the Singapore Ministry of Education.
- **Closer to home:** Singapore is just four to five hours (on average) away from most big cities in India. This can be of immense comfort to parents who would like their child to get a world-class education but do not want to send him very far away from home.
- **Work while studying:** Singapore allows most international students who demonstrate financial need to work up to 16 hours a week, and full time during the holidays – helping to defray some of the student's costs.
- **Easier to get employment after graduating:** It is reasonably easy for a student to work in Singapore after completing his education, as the visa laws are not very restrictive.
- **Good quality of living:** Singapore is a vibrant city in the heart of Asia, a great mix of the East and the West. With a cosmopolitan culture and a racially diverse people who live in harmony, the country is well known for its cleanliness, low crime rates, high quality of living and excellent public transport. It is also an ideal base for travelling within the region, giving your child a wonderful opportunity to explore the surrounding areas!

Universities in Singapore

There are four local universities — National University of Singapore (NUS), Nanyang Technological University (NTU), Singapore Management University (SMU) and Singapore University of Technology and Design (SUTD). In addition, there are several international universities that have their Asian campuses located in Singapore, offering your child the chance to obtain a degree from a world-renowned university like INSEAD or University of Chicago for a fraction of the overseas tuition fee. (These function as arms of their parent institutions, and applications have to be made individually to each one).

- **National University of Singapore (NUS):** Established in 1905, NUS is one of the oldest universities in Asia. It is Singapore's flagship university, with 16 faculties and schools across three campus locations in the island. NUS is ranked 25th among the top universities in the world, and offers courses in major disciplines such as the sciences, engineering, technology, law, arts & social sciences and medicine. Around 37,000 students from over 100 countries study in NUS, contributing to a diverse and vibrant student body.
- **Nanyang Technological University (NTU):** NTU (Nanyang is the Chinese name for the Southeast-Asian region) was set up in 1981 to provide facilities for tertiary education and research in engineering and technology. The university's strengths are in science and technology, although it also offers excellent programmes in accountancy, business and communication studies. It has four colleges with 12 schools, and four autonomous entities. More than 33,500 students from over 66 countries study at NTU, and it is ranked 47th in the world.
- **Singapore Management University (SMU):** SMU is Singapore's first publicly-funded private university with a focus on business and management programmes. It is now an autonomous university with more than 7200 students, and comprises six schools offering undergraduate, graduate, and PhD programmes in Business Management, Accountancy, Economics, Information Systems Management, Law and the Social Sciences. It is one of the youngest universities to receive accreditation from the oldest global accrediting body, AACSB International.
- **Singapore University of Technology and Design (SUTD):** This is Singapore's newest university, established in 2008, and offers education in science, technology, arts, humanities, and social sciences. SUTD was developed in collaboration with the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) and Zhejiang University of China.

International universities with campuses in Singapore

- INSEAD
- University of Chicago Graduate School of Business
- SP Jain Centre of Management
- ESSEC
- Digipen Institute of Technology
- University of Nevada, Las Vegas (UNLV)
- New York University Tisch School of the Arts Asia
- German Institute of Science and Technology
- EDHEC Business School

Applying to a university in Singapore

Most Indian students are eligible to apply for an undergraduate degree in a Singapore university soon after Grade 12 or its equivalent. However, be warned that it is not easy to get admission. Singapore attracts extremely bright students from most of South-East Asia – China, Malaysia, Vietnam, Indonesia, India and, of course, Singapore itself. So, the older established institutions like NUS and NTU have an average cut-off of 92-94% in Grade 12, or above 40 in IB. Singapore universities give a high weightage to academic scores, although a stellar extra-curricular portfolio may help to better your child's chances. While NUS and NTU do not require Indian students to take the SAT or the TOEFL test, a good score can help in your child's admission process. On the other hand, SMU and SUTD require both SAT and TOEFL scores.

Applications for an undergraduate course usually open in October of the previous year. Your child will have to choose the course he is applying to; certain courses may require a written test and an interview before placement. Each university in Singapore, whether it is a local university, or the Asian campus of a foreign university, has its own application form, which you can access from its website. The application process is quite straight forward; the universities are extremely efficient and get back to you with any questions you may have. Copies of the requisite academic certificates need to be provided to support the application. One can choose to apply to up to five courses, listing them in your order of preference. Applications must be accompanied by an application fee between S$20-30.

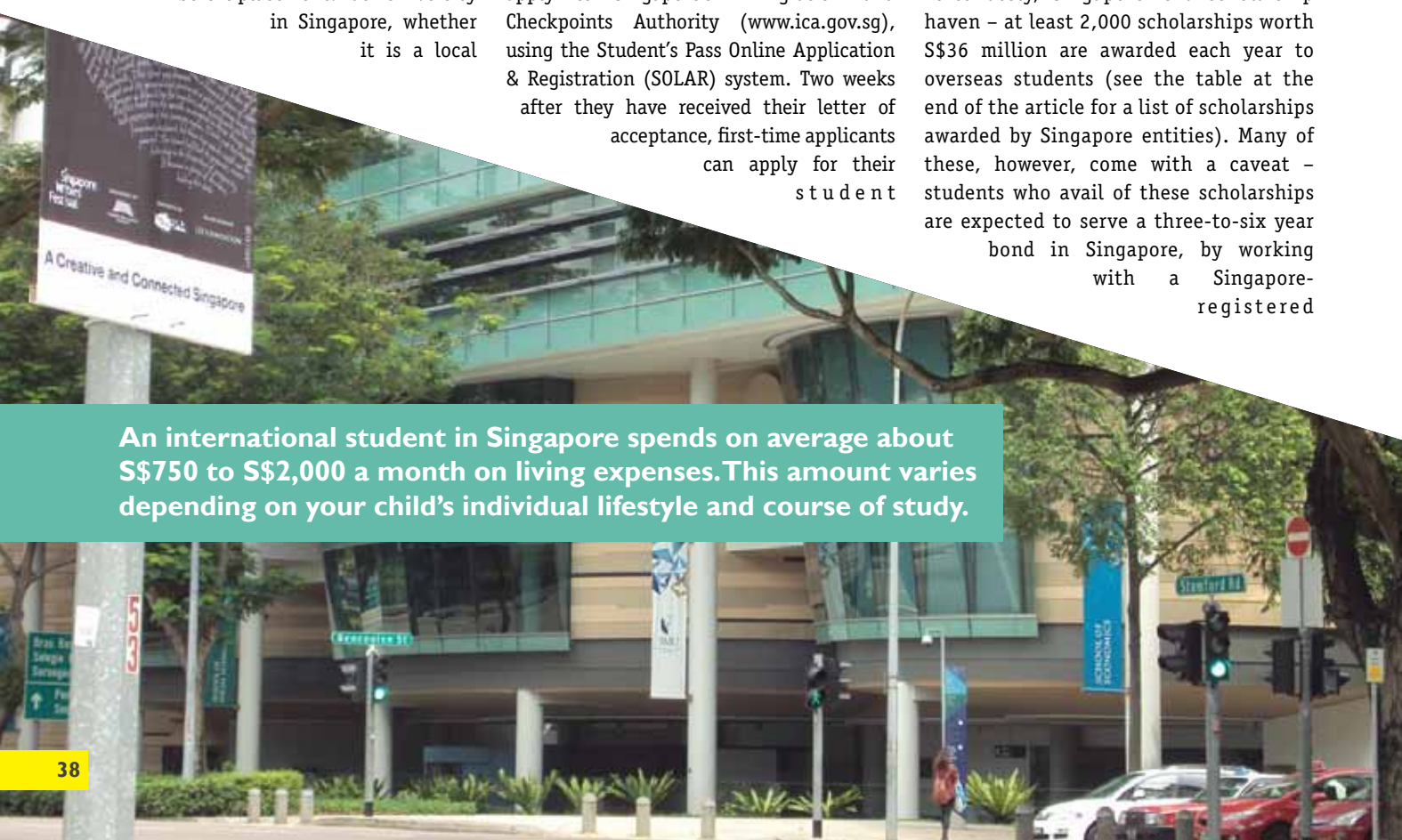
If the application is accepted by the university, the student gets either a conditional or unconditional offer of acceptance. Under a conditional offer, the university may ask for additional documentation, such as an essay, to strengthen the offer; or, the admission may be pending the final exam results.

Once your child has received an acceptance letter from the university, he will have to apply for a student visa (known as Student's Pass in Singapore). He must apply to Singapore's Immigration and Checkpoints Authority (www.ica.gov.sg), using the Student's Pass Online Application & Registration (SOLAR) system. Two weeks after they have received their letter of acceptance, first-time applicants can apply for their student visa. The application must be submitted not more than two months, and not less than one month, before their course begins. Applications are processed quickly, usually in about 10 working days, although it could take longer in the busy months of July and August. A processing fee of S$30 is required for every application submitted to ICA. In addition, ICA charges S$60 as issuance fee for every student's pass issued and a further S$30 multiple-entry visa fee for students from countries requiring a visa to enter Singapore (India is one of them).

Financing your child's education

Undergraduate education at Singapore's universities is highly subsidised by the Government of Singapore, which pays for the bulk of the operating costs besides the infrastructural costs at the universities. Even though the tuition fees for international students in Singapore are lower than many other countries at approximately USD 22,000 per annum on average, this can still be a stretch for some.

Fortunately, Singapore is a scholarship haven – at least 2,000 scholarships worth S$36 million are awarded each year to overseas students (see the table at the end of the article for a list of scholarships awarded by Singapore entities). Many of these, however, come with a caveat – students who avail of these scholarships are expected to serve a three-to-six year bond in Singapore, by working with a Singapore-registered



An international student in Singapore spends on average about S$750 to S$2,000 a month on living expenses. This amount varies depending on your child's individual lifestyle and course of study.

company of their choice upon graduation. Students will have to find these jobs themselves. Earlier, foreign scholarship holders were automatically given Permanent Resident status upon graduation, but since 2010, that provision has been withdrawn, making it more difficult for international students to compete with local citizens to find jobs. Hence, we advise you to weigh the pros and cons carefully before committing to a bond, and check out the job prospects for your child's field of study and course, as well as his future plans for post-graduate studies.

Living in Singapore

Accommodation

Most universities have an international student office to help their students find on-campus or off-campus accommodation to suit their budget and needs. First year international students usually live on campus, in Halls of Residence accommodation provided by the university. City campus universities like SMU provide hostel accommodation to their students near the university. Accommodation is either single room or shared, fully furnished, and there are common amenities such as TV rooms, laundry, computer rooms, game rooms and so on. Meal packages are available at extra charge, and most halls provide kitchenette facilities for students to cook their own food.

There is also a wide range of off-campus accommodation available. Private hostels, run by the educational institutions or by private agencies, provide accommodation on a single or shared basis. The usual facilities include wifi in rooms, daily cleaning, laundry services, food centre, and round the clock security arrangements. Homestay is another option for an international student to consider; this involves living with a local family with full food and board. Lastly, international students can opt for private housing, an expensive option but one that affords most flexibility and privacy.

While helping your child choose the kind of accommodation he wants, bear in mind that real estate in Singapore is extremely expensive, especially apartments that are in the heart of the city or close to an MRT station.

Guide on the cost of living in Singapore

Item	Average per month in S$
Accommodation	S$200-S$1,500 (rentals vary with geographical area, type of accommodation, demand, facilities provided and the number of people sharing)
Utilities	S$50-S$80
Food	S$200-S$450
Public transport	S$40-S$100 (varies with type of student concession pass)
Telecommunications	S$30-S$50 (varies with usage and package)
Books & Stationery	S$30-S$100 (varies with courses)
Medical Hospitalisation Insurance	S$5 - S$8
Personal expenses	S$100-S$200 (varies with individuals)
Estimated	S$650-$2,000



Getting around

Singapore's small size and fantastic transport infrastructure means that getting around in Singapore is extremely easy. The three main modes of public transport are the Mass Rapid Transit (MRT) or the metro rail system, public buses, and taxis. The MRT as well as the bus system are affordable, efficient and quick, and most international students get used to making their way around the island via these mass transit options. Taxis are also a good option, but are the most expensive of the three public transport options.

Living

Singapore is the smallest country in South-East Asia, but what it lacks in size it makes up for in variety. This 704 square km island is home to just under five million people with four official languages. It has a fascinating mix of three main races – the Chinese, the Malays and the Indians – in addition to a generous sprinkling of people from countries near and far - Australians, Indonesians, other South-east Asians, and westerners. It is well known for its low crime rate and high levels of safety. The country offers enough options, whether your child is a nature lover, a sports buff, a culture-vulture or a combination of all of the above. The large Indian population, and the country's long history of trade with India, makes for a wonderful mixture of the familiar and the foreign that helps international students from India adjust quickly to living and studying abroad.



Health

Singapore is well known for its high standard of cleanliness that carries through from street vendors to public bathrooms. Consequently, health standards are quite high, (bird flu epidemics not withstanding!), especially when compared to India.

However, as medical expenses can be costly in Singapore, most universities insist that international students buy some kind of medical insurance that is administered by the university, or by a private agency on behalf of the university. This costs between S$50-100 per semester, and the insurance usually covers the basic anticipated needs of a healthy individual in the student's age-group. If you think that the coverage offered does not adequately protect your child, you have the option to enrol with a private health insurance organisation for additional services.

We hope we have given you most of the information you will need to decide on an under-graduate education in Singapore for your child. Singapore as a nation believes in education, and its universities offer high standards of teaching and learning, great links with industry and a dedication to education and research. We think your child will greatly benefit from a Singapore education, and you too will find comfort in his proximity and the fact that you didn't have to break the bank to provide him with a world-class education!

Each individual college may also offer scholarships to international students – do check the websites of the colleges for more details. Also check the Scholarship Guide (http://www.scholarshipguide.com.sg/), which provides detailed information on the scholarships available in Singapore.

Organisation/ scholarship	Aid provided	University	Is there a bond?	Contact
Dr Goh Keng Swee Scholarship	Three to four scholarships awarded every year	NUS, NTU, SMU, SUTD	Yes, for three years	http://www.pscscholarships.gov.sg/content/pscsch/default/scholarshipapplication/otherscholarships/gks_scholarship.html
Science & Technology Undergraduate Scholarship	Awarded for undergraduate studies in computing, engineering and science	NUS	Yes, for six years	http://www.nus.edu.sg/oam/scholarships/freshmen/nsg/scholarship-science-technology.html
SIA-NOL Undergraduate scholarship	Awarded for undergraduate studies in engineering and science	NUS, NTU	Yes, for six years	http://admissions.ntu.edu.sg/UndergraduateAdmissions/Pages/SIANOLUndergraduateScholarship.aspx
Nanyang Scholarship	Awarded to outstanding freshmen pursuing undergraduate programmes at NTU	NTU	Yes, for three years	http://admissions.ntu.edu.sg/UndergraduateAdmissions/Pages/NanyangScholarship.aspx
JTC scholarship	Awarded to students to study in Singapore or overseas – the United States, United Kingdom, Japan, China, Germany and France	NUS, NTU, SMU	Service obligation of five to six years with JTC	http://www.jtc.gov.sg/careers/Pages/Undergraduate-Scholarship.aspx
SGX Scholarship	Awarded to students to study subjects related to the finance industry	NUS, NTU, SMU	Scholars will be committed to work for SGX for a two-year period	https://career.sgx.com/scholarships/
College Scholarship	Awarded to outstanding freshmen pursuing undergraduate programmes at NTU	NTU	Yes, for three years	http://admissions.ntu.edu.sg/UndergraduateAdmissions/Pages/CollegeScholarship.aspx
Kewalram Chanrai Group Endowed Scholarship	Available to first-year full-time undergraduates of foreign nationalities pursuing any degree programme	SMU	No	http://www2.smu.edu.sg/financial/scholarships/Kewalram_Chanri_Group.asp
Lim Hang Hing Scholarship	Available for students of social studies	SMU	No	http://www2.smu.edu.sg/financial/scholarships/Lim_Hang_Hing.asp
N.R. Thadani Scholarship	Available to full-time undergraduates of Indian nationality pursuing any degree programme	SMU	No	http://www2.smu.edu.sg/financial/scholarships/Thadani.asp
The Ian Ferguson Foundation Scholarship	Available to full-time undergraduates	SMU	No	http://www2.smu.edu.sg/financial/scholarships/Is_ianferguson.asp



Nandita Shenoy is currently studying at the Nanyang Academy of Fine Arts (NAFA), Singapore, after completing her Cambridge A levels at Vidyashilp Academy, Bangalore

Did you apply to study in any other country besides Singapore? If yes, why did you choose Singapore over these countries?

I also applied to colleges in London and India. But I chose NAFA because I got a tuition grant from the Government of Singapore; this is not common elsewhere at an undergrad level. Also, I had been to Singapore before and I really liked the place, and found the people in Singapore accepting and warm. Of course, it is an added advantage that Singapore is close to India!

What about your choice of college? Why NAFA?

One of the main reasons was the quality of the institute – NAFA is considered among the best colleges for design and media, which is my area of interest. I also wanted exposure to design concepts from the East. Two other reasons I chose NAFA was that I get a diploma at the end of three years and a degree on completion of the fourth year.

How long did you spend on the application and admission process and what your experience like?

NAFA has a representative in Chennai through whom the institute processes all applications. Students from India have to go through this designated representative. I applied in July/August 2011; the application process was not complicated. The entrance test takes place twice a year — December and April. Results are available in January and May respectively. I chose to do it in December 2011 so that I could know about my admission before completing my A levels (Std. XII) in June 2012. I joined in July 2012 on the basis of my A Level scores, which were out in August.

The entire process was transparent and flowed smoothly. The Singapore dollar had gone up to Rs 45 in a short period of 6-8 months during my application process. Hence the tuition grant was a big help. The only tedious process was finding the accommodation — 6 of us girls share an apartment here.

How has your experience been so far – the academics, the college life, the cultural adjustments?

Academics in India, I feel, are focused on following a set pattern, a little more traditional. Although art & design colleges in India help you find your individual style, studying in Singapore has made me culturally aware as well. Not only am I recognising my individual style but also learning the styles of the various different cultures in Singapore. Here, the teachers can give you individual attention as the class size is much smaller. The minute I joined college I fit right in, everybody was very welcoming. The workload is enough to keep you on your toes at all times but not excessive enough to keep you from the rest of the activities available here.

I have been living in Singapore for five months now. Personally I think Singapore is amazing for a student. A lot of places offer student discounts and concession cards. Living on a tight budget, this really helps. Singapore is one of the safest countries. I love visiting art galleries, museums, theaters and the beach. My friends and I often take walks to Marina Bay just to relax and soak in the beauty. Singapore nightlife is amazing with its variety of dance clubs and concerts to go to. I had recently gone for the Formula1 and Nicky Romero (Dutch DJ) concert and had the time of my life.

Transportation in Singapore is a dream. The bus and train routes are widespread, easily understandable and the cheapest modes of transportation. For me I think it was easy to settle in as there is a huge Indian community. From the yummiest *dosa* or cheese *naan* to the best Bollywood movies, Singapore has it all.

Do you have any advice for Indian students considering an undergrad education in Singapore?

Singapore is a home away from home. I think it is the perfect place for students.